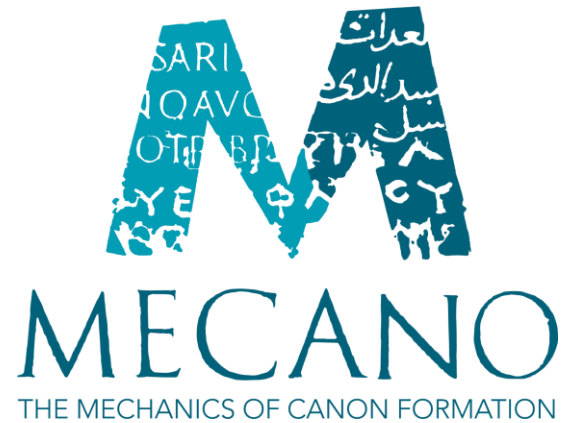




From Annotation to Interpretation: Exploring Pliny the Elder's *Naturalis Historia* through Semantic Linking

*Digital Humanities for Greek and Latin Linguistics and
Philology*

Sunoikisis DC Digital Scholarly Editions in Classics,
Byzantine, and Medieval Studies: Session 7

9th June 2026

Valeria Irene Boano
KU Leuven (Belgium)



**Funded by
the European Union**

MSCA Doctoral Networks 2022 | [GA 101120349](https://mecano-dn.eu)
<https://mecano-dn.eu>

From digital annotation to text interpretation: where to start?

The case of the *Naturalis Historia*

Introduction

Why digitally annotating a Latin corpus?

- ▶ Semantic annotation allows to easily **extract information** about entities mentioned in the text
- ▶ Linguistic annotation enables the analysis of the **linguistic features** of a big corpus
- ▶ Together they offer the chance to analyze previously debated scholarly issues from a new angle with a **distant reading approach**

Introduction

The case of Pliny the Elder's *Naturalis Historia*

- ▶ **Many-voiced work** (Murphy 2004): many people are mentioned as sources, witnesses or protagonists of episodes
- ▶ Exploring the mentions of the individuals cited in the Latin encyclopedia in their **textual context**
- ▶ Understanding the mechanics of the selection performed by the author
- ▶ Focus on books 2-6 (geographical and astronomical topics)
- ▶ MECANO doctoral network: <https://mecano-dn.eu/>.

Data and Methodology

Implementing a digital pipeline

Step 1

Creating a high-quality digital corpus

When performing semantic annotation, it becomes crucial to work with a **high-quality digital text**

Optical Character Recognition (OCR):
automatic conversion of images containing text into machine-readable format

Mayhoff's critical edition (1892)

- OCR generated (Perseus Digital Library)
- Tokenized and lemmatized (Clérice 2021)

Tokenization: breaking down the text into smaller pieces (e.g. words)
Lemmatization: linking tokens to their own citation forms (lemmas)

Text quality assessment

Philological level

Formatting level

Step 1

Creating a high-quality digital corpus

Correction of the text:

- ▶ **Formatting** level: correction of the OCR errors
- ▶ **Philological** level: integration of different variant readings printed in Conte's edition (Barchiesi et al., 1982)
- ▶ Text stored in a **relational database**: data stored in one or more tables, linked between each other
- ▶ Exploiting relational database **unique ids** to keep the text **compatible** with the original version
- ▶ Always possible to retrieve the original version and to distinguish between different types of modification

Step 2

Enhancing the text with automatic annotation

Linguistic annotation

New lemmatization and Part-of-Speech tagging

Part-of-Speech tagging: assigning grammatical categories (e.g. verb, noun...) to tokens

Automatic Annotation: how to find the best model?

- ▶ Trying with different models and evaluating the performance on a sample of 1000 tokens to choose the model with the best performance
- ▶ **Collatinus model:** trained on the LASLA corpus (classical Latin, manually annotated), and enriched with LatinBERT (Verkerk 2024)

Automatic annotation

Step 2

Enhancing the text with automatic annotation

Named Entity Recognition (NER)

NER: automatic identification and classification of proper names in running text into predefined categories such as Persons, Places, Organizations.

- ▶ Annotation of **persons**, defined as “any identifiable single individual” (Palladino et al. 2024)
- ▶ Definition of project-specific annotation guidelines
- ▶ Use of the **LatinBERT model fine-tuned** on this specific task (Beersmans et al., 2023)
- ▶ **Results correction and model evaluation:**
 - ▶ Bad precision due to the high number of populations and places mentioned only in this text: a lot of entities misclassified as persons
- ▶ Use of the linguistic annotation and the corrected OCR to speed and smooth the correction process

Semi-automatic annotation

Step 3

The linking: Wikidata and the Realencyclopädie

Wikidata

- ▶ Free, open and collaborative knowledge base
- ▶ Exploitation of structured data (e.g. M. Varro → citizenship → Ancient Rome)
- ▶ Enhancement of the coverage of the knowledge base with respect to the ancient world

Realencyclopädie der Classischen Altertumswissenschaft (RE)

- ▶ Fundamental prosopographical reference work for the ancient world
- ▶ Entities extracted from the **Wikisource digitized text**
- ▶ New database part of the Trismegistos environment (de Graaf et al. 2024)
- ▶ Unique identifier for each entry

Extracting and modeling the information

Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database

- ▶ The case of M. Varro:
 - **Instance of** → human
 - **Citizenship** → Ancient Rome
 - **Language** → Latin
 - **Occupation(s)** → writer; poet; music theorist; philosopher; historian; grammarian; annalist; military personnel
 - **Sex or gender** → male

Each mention is enriched with this information, while keeping it in its textual context.

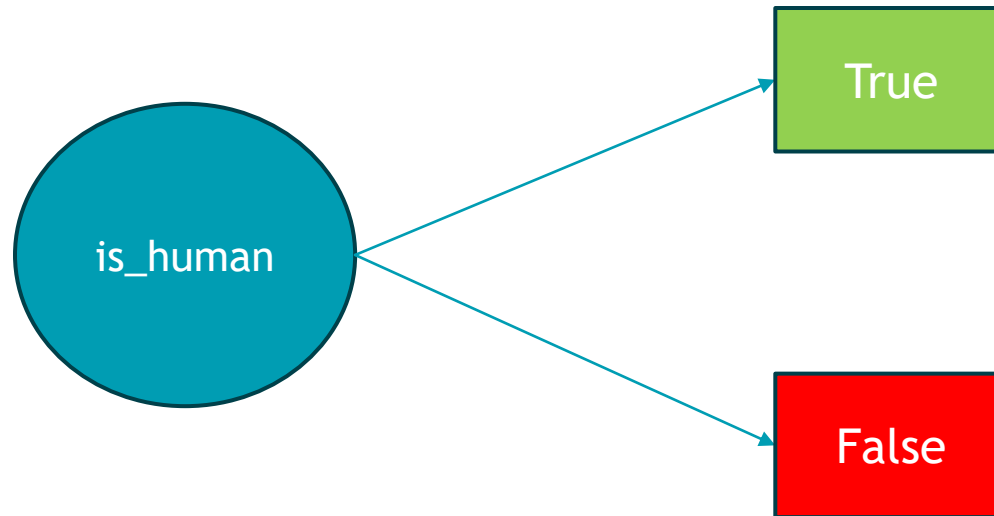
Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database

- ▶ The case of M. Varro:
 - Instance of → human

The property values contain heterogenous information (e.g. citizenship: Ionian League, Miletus, Samos...):
we need to model the data in a uniform way

Each mention is enriched with this information, while keeping it in its
textual context.

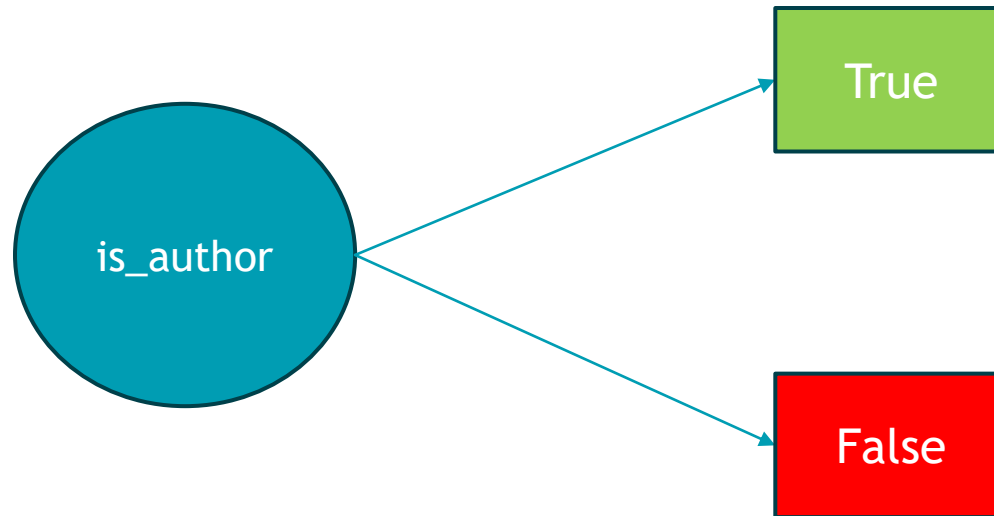
Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database



Based on the “instance of” (P31) value

- True: “human”, “human whose existence is disputed”, “prosopographical phantom”

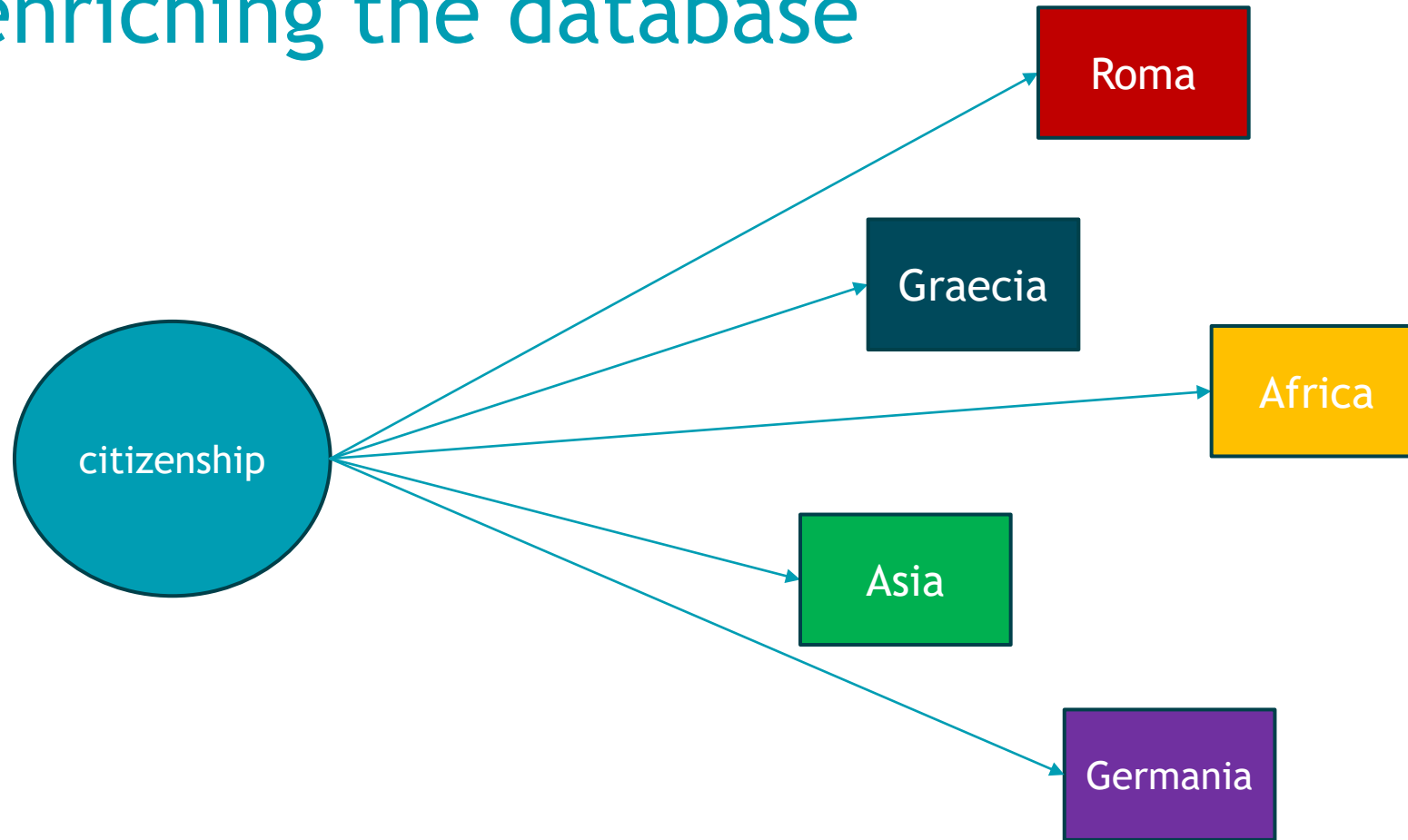
Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database



Based on the “occupation” (P106) value:
at least one “authorial” occupation in the list

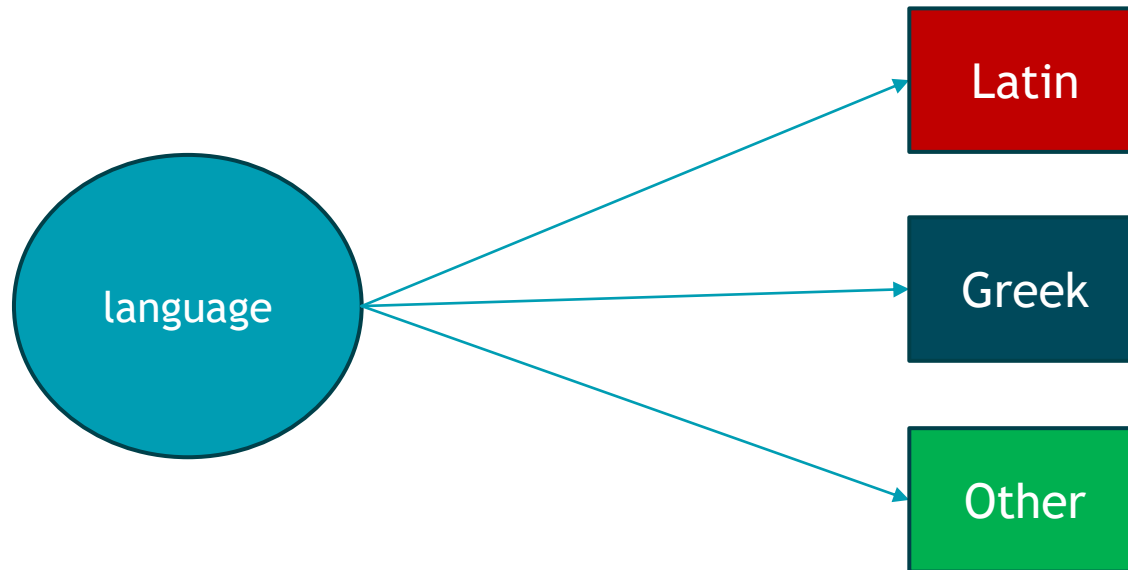
- ▶ Manual check of the results, to remove errors
- ▶ Comparison with list of sources in index, to spot any other inconsistency

Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database



Based on the “citizenship” (P27) value

Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database



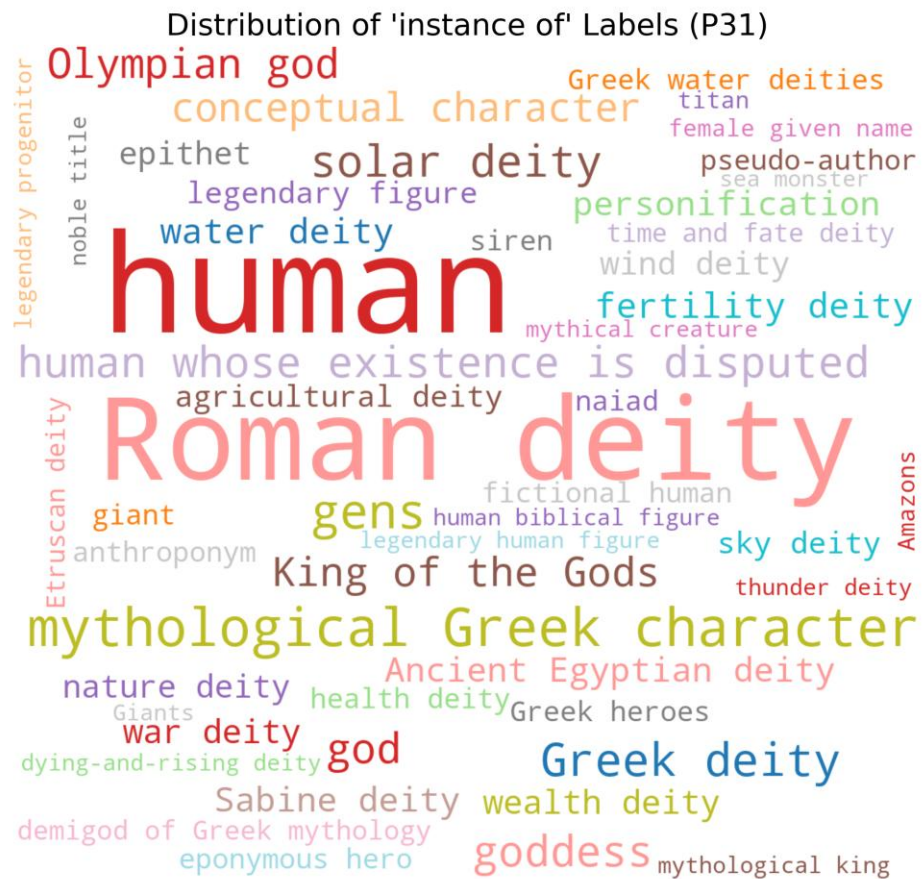
Based on the “languages spoken, written or signed” (P1412) value

Extracting information from Wikidata: enriching the database

Geographical and cultural aspects do not align with our modern conception: e.g.
many individuals of Greek culture and language lived on the African and Asian
continent

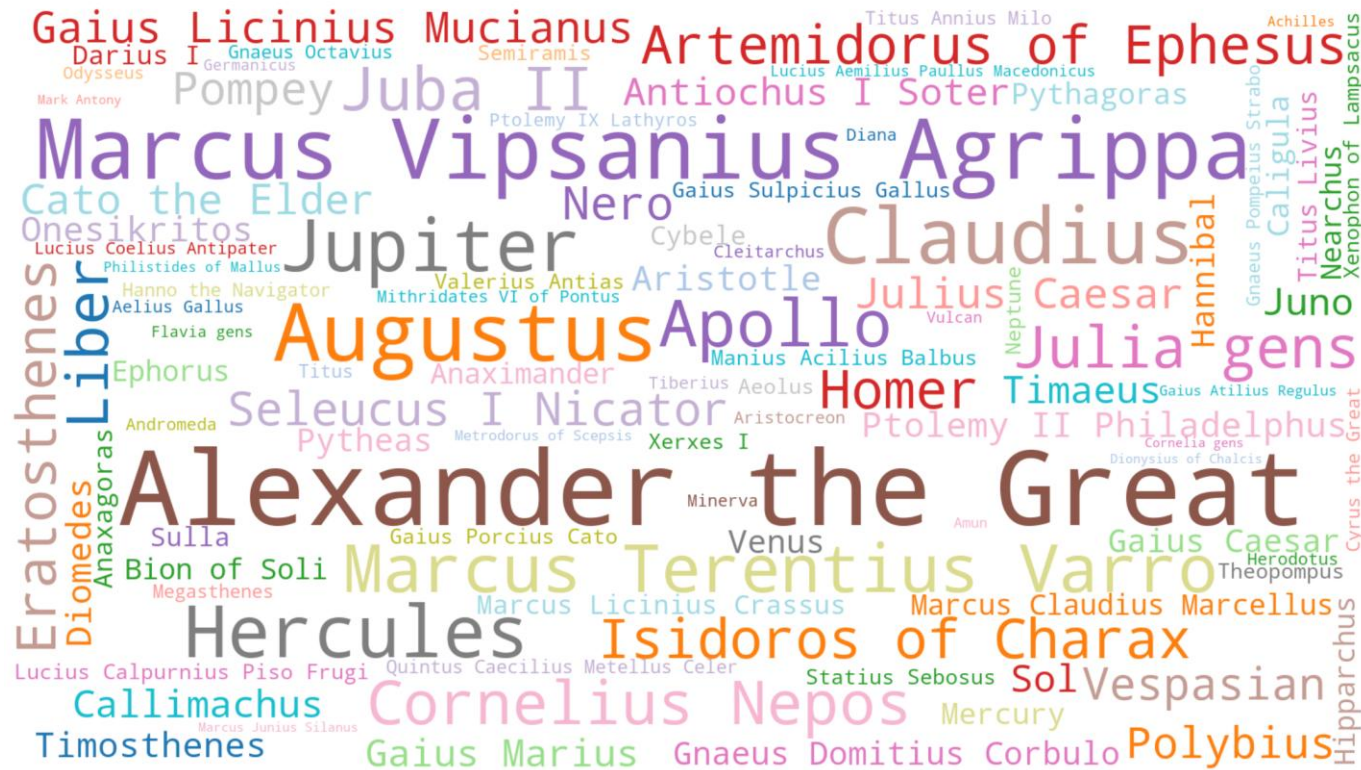
**Separate modelling of the two aspects allows to analyze each of them
separately**

What kind of individuals?



Who? A look at the most cited Wikidata labels

Most cited individuals in book 2-6 of the Naturalis Historia: Wikidata labels



From annotation to interpretation

Pliny the Elder and the Greeks: admiration or contempt? A case study

Introduction : Pliny and the relationship with the Greeks

What is the attitude of Pliny towards the Greeks, the Romans and other nationalities mentioned in the books?

Scholarship is divided, specifically regarding the relation with the Greeks.

- **Critical relationship** with the Greeks, responsible of the moral decline of Rome (Carey 2003, pp. 23-25; Schilling 1978; French 1994).
- **Great admiration** of Greek authorities, and criticism only towards bad quality sources (Fögen 2013; Serbat 1987).

Greek science in general is characterized by misplaced ingenuity and vanity (Wallace-Hadrill 1990, p. 93).

Pline éprouve une admiration sans limite pour les savants grecs authentiques; mais une vive hostilité à l'égard de tous les charlatans hellénophones (Serbat 1986, pp. 2092-2093)

Introduction : Pliny and the relationship with the Greeks

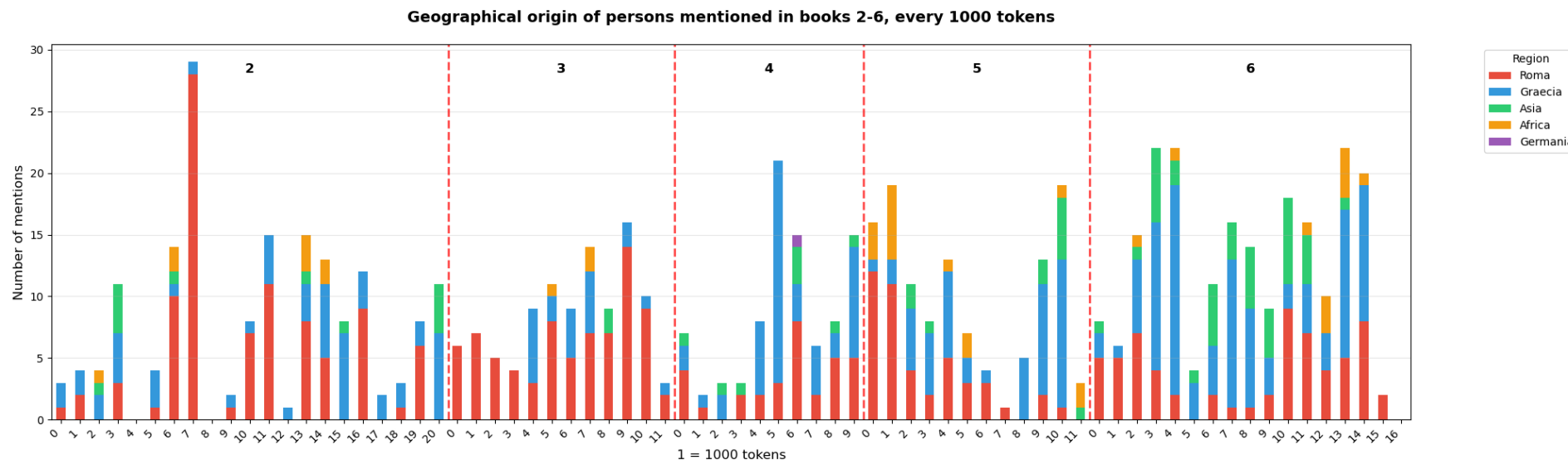
Can semantic annotation of the text help us to shed a light on this problem?

Using Python to perform a first general analysis of the distribution of different nationalities.

- *How many Greeks and Romans (and other geographical origins)?*
- *How often are they cited?*
- *How does this change when looking only at authors?*
- *What distribution in the text?*
- *How often are unique authors cited?*

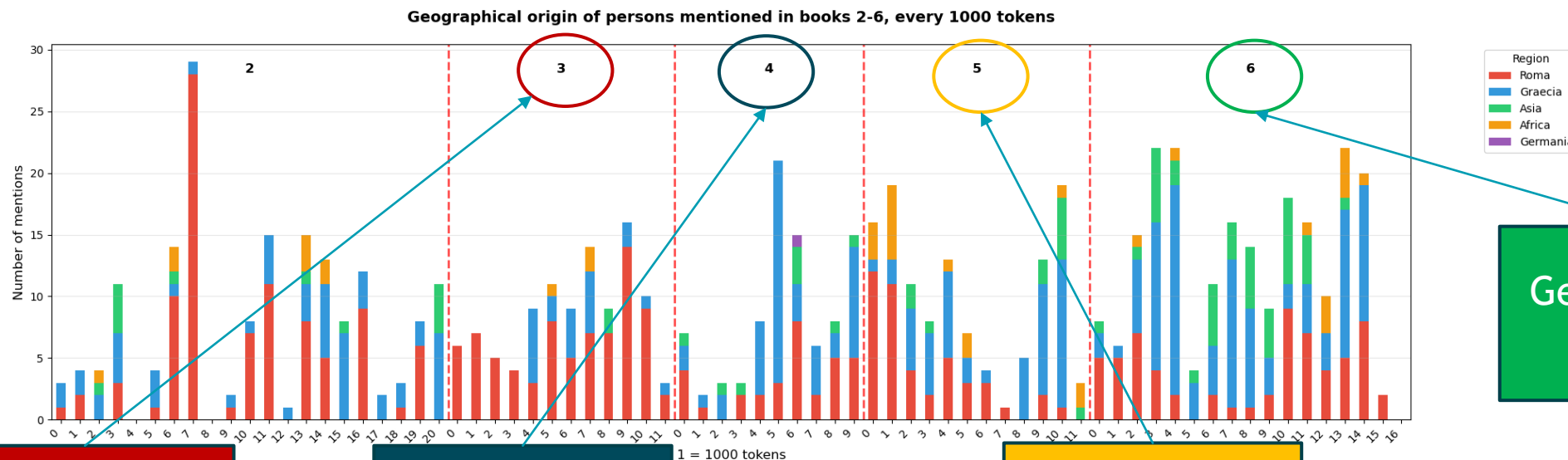
Distribution of different citizenships in the corpus

How many individuals of each nationality are mentioned every 1000 tokens?



Distribution of different citizenships in the corpus

How many individuals of each nationality are mentioned every 1000 tokens?



Geography of
Italy

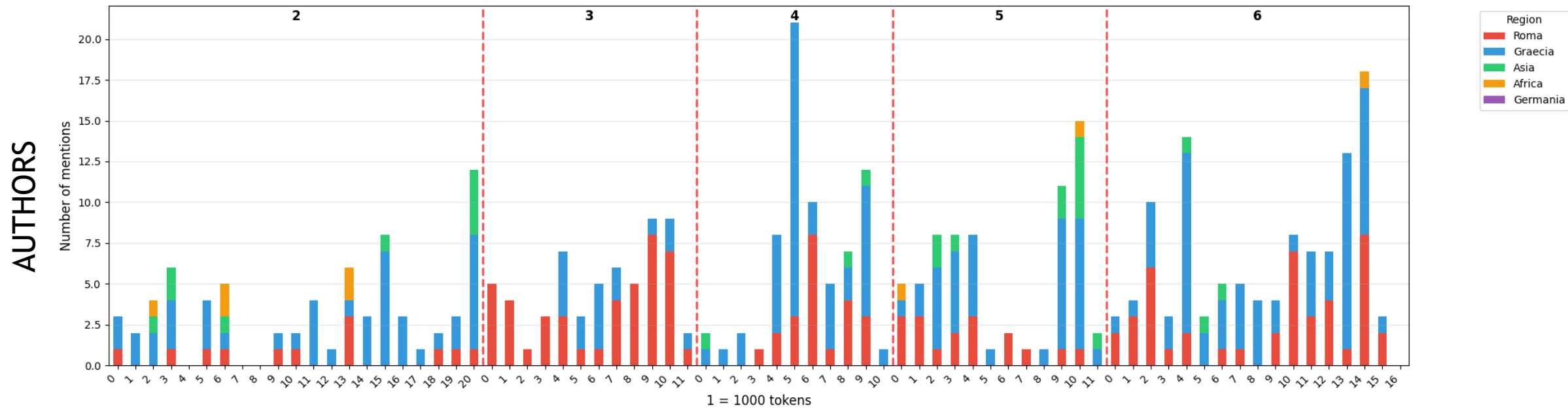
Geography of
Greece

Geography of
Africa

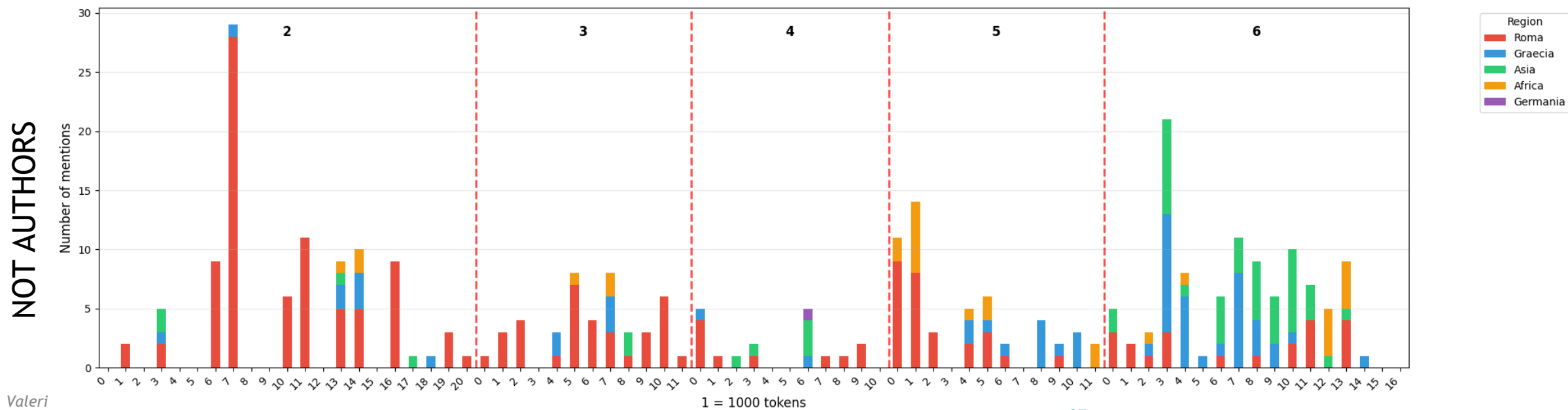
Geography of
Asia

What happens if we restrict the results only to (not) authors?

Geographical origin of authors mentioned in books 2-6, every 1000 tokens



Geographical origin of not authors mentioned in books 2-6, every 1000 tokens



Distribution of different citizenships in the corpus: authors vs not authors

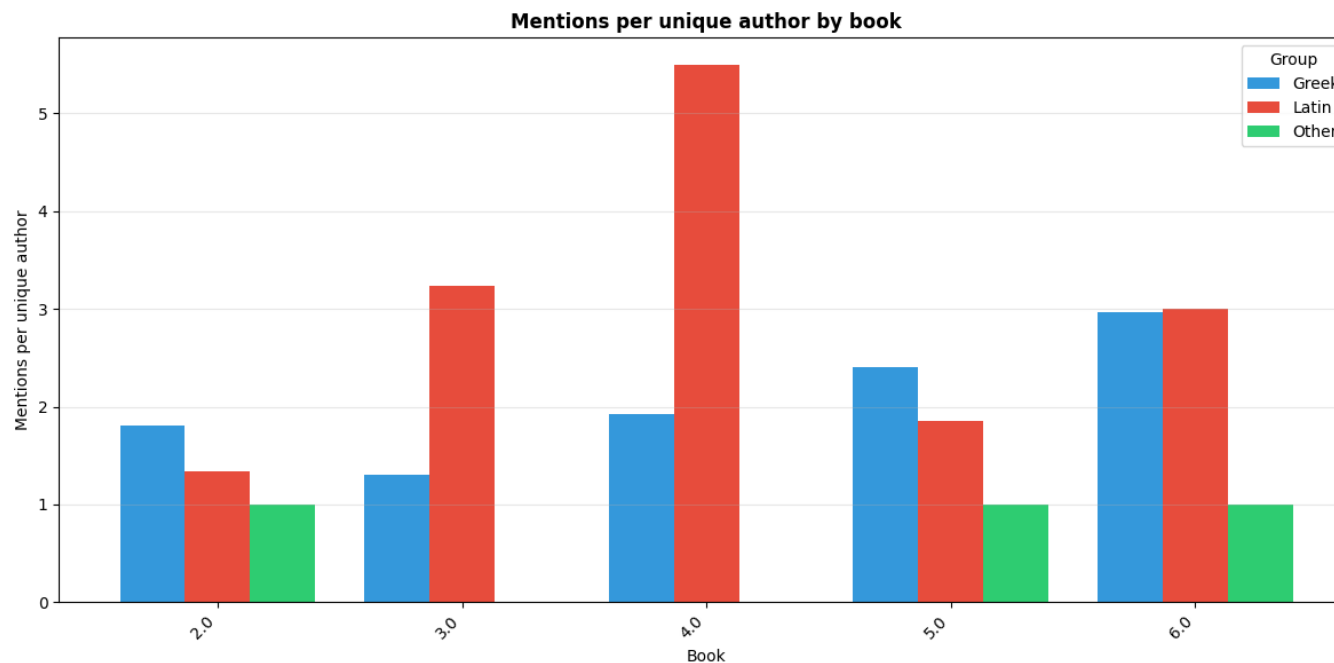
- If we restrict our results only to **authors**, we see that the Romans lose their predominance, in favor of the **Greeks**.
- **Not authors**, instead, are mostly **Roman citizens**.
 - Book 6 is an exception: here Alexander the Great (= Greek) is mentioned 32 times, and in 28 of those cases he is not mentioned as a source.
- Individuals pertaining to Africa and Asia mentioned in books 5 and 6 are mostly not authors

Now, let's compare the total mentions and the unique authors.

Focusing on authors: mentions vs unique individuals

We can inspect the data by looking at the ratio between the total mentions and the unique authors

= How often is each unique author cited, on average?



Less Latin authors, cited more often

Book 3

Language	Total mentions	Unique authors
Latin	42	13
Greek	17	13

Geography of
Italy
Predictable (?)

Book 4

Language	Total mentions	Unique authors
Latin	22	4
Greek	48	25

Geography of
Greece
(!!!)

The Latin authors mentioned in book 4 are: Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa, Marcus Terentius Varro, Gaius Licinius Mucianus, and Cornelius Nepos.

- ▶ Agrippa alone is mentioned 12 times!

Less Latin authors, cited more often

- ▶ If we look at the totality of the 5 books, the difference is even more evident: **24 Latin authors are mentioned for a total of 116 times!**

Language	Total mentions	Unique authors
Greek	257	79
Latin	116	24
Other	5	3

This means that, on average:

- A Greek author is mentioned 3,25 times
 - A Latin authors is mentioned 4,83 times
- **Predominance of citations of Latin authors.**

First conclusions

- In terms of number of authors, Greeks are predominant → **majority of Greek sources.**
- However, **Latin sources are cited more often:** in particular, the top 5 authors are mentioned a great number of times.
- This gives us a first idea of **Pliny's preference for Roman sources,** even if he could not do without the Greek ones.
- This does not automatically mean that he despised the Greeks.

Conclusion

Main take-aways

The use of semantic annotation can be fruitfully integrated within more traditional approaches to the study of text

- ▶ Importance of the **textual quality** when working with semantic information
- ▶ Integration of **automatic and manual approaches** to smooth the annotation process
- ▶ Importance of linking external information to elements of the text while keeping them in their **textual context**

Exercise

- ▶ You can find the exercise at this link (GoogleColab):
- ▶ <https://colab.research.google.com/drive/1AlHM6tbCd1nWPRkhgre3CwCTWGYydBbb?usp=sharing>
- ▶ **First create a copy on your own drive** (otherwise you will overwrite the code for everybody 😊)
- ▶ You will be able to perform the analysis on a restricted version of the corpus (“nh2_sample_sunoikisis.csv”)
- ▶ Follow the instructions on the notebook!

Thank you for your attention!

Any questions?

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ALMA MATER STUDIORUM
UNIVERSITÀ DI BOLOGNA

**Digital Humanities for
Greek and Latin
Linguistics and
Philology**

9.6.2026

Ancient Greek Proper Names and the lead tablets from Styra

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LILEC, University of Bologna

Roadmap

1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)
2. Between epigraphic and philological editing
3. The linguistics of proper names
4. Conclusions
5. Exercises

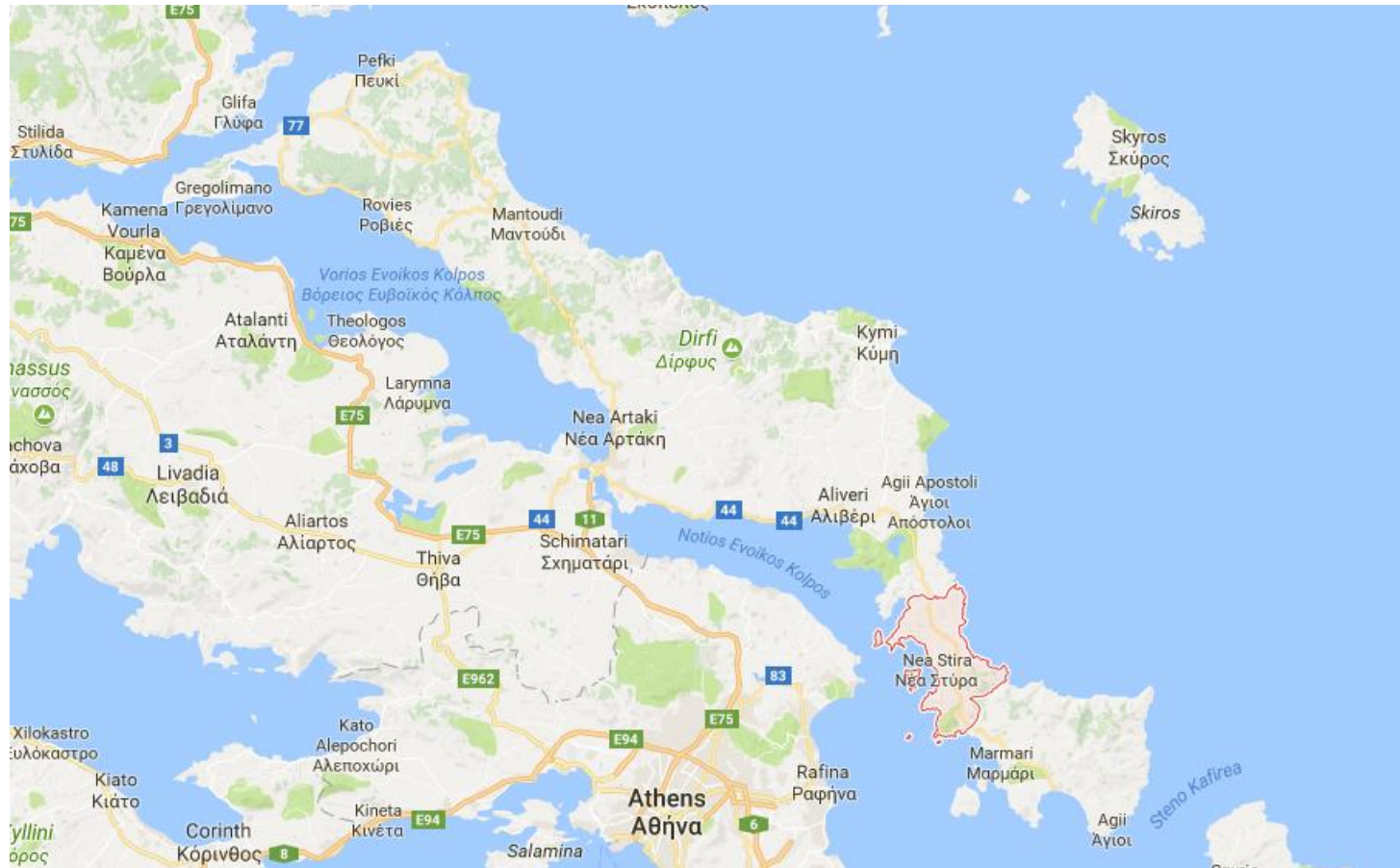


1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)

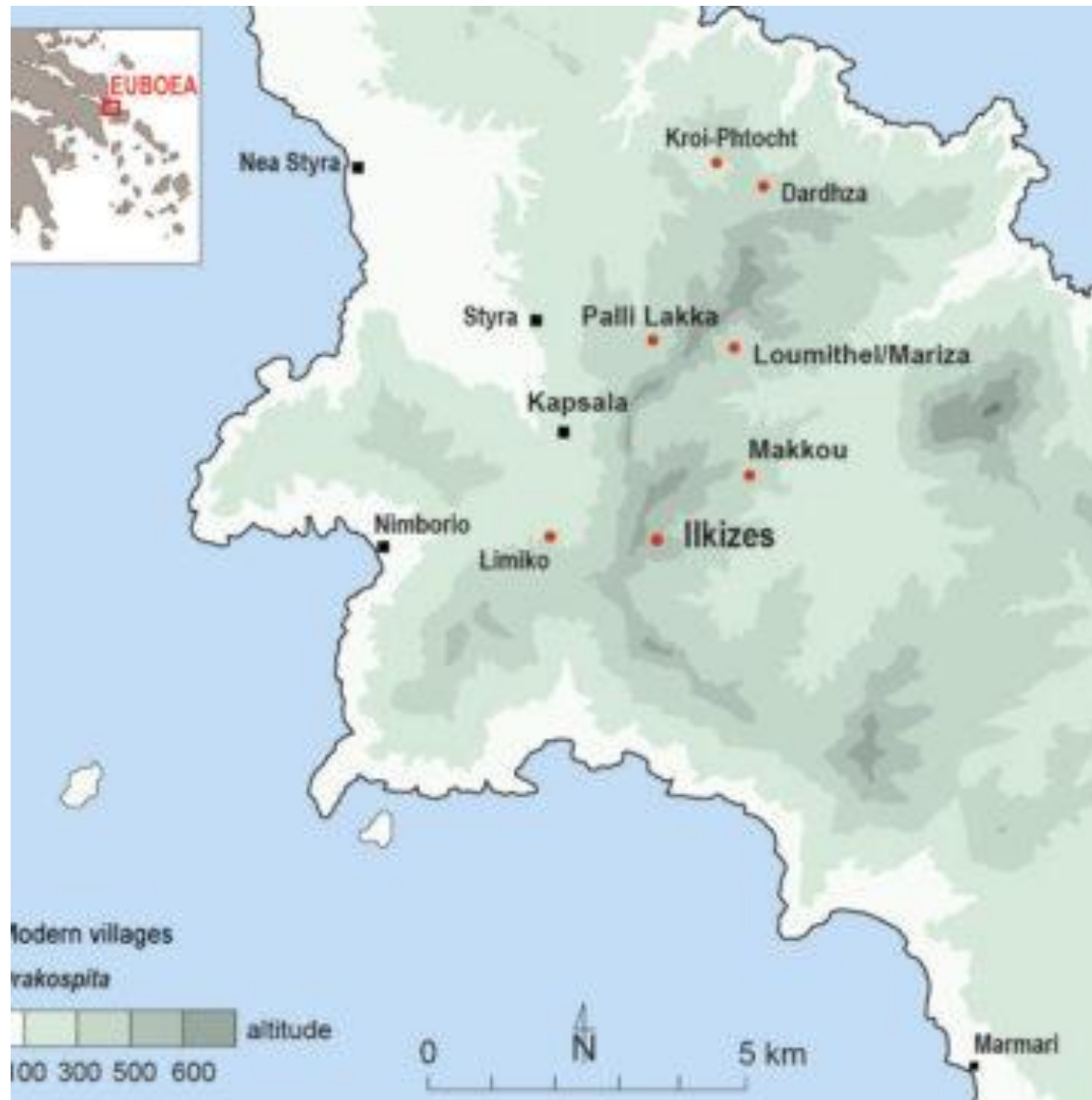
- **A corpus of c. 500 lead tablets** used as *tesserae publicae* (for voting, drawing lots and/or recording citizens' presences)
- **Dated to c. 475 BCE**
- **Discovered near Styra (Southern Euboea)**, deposited together after disposal; several tablets show clear evidence of reuse and multiple layers of writing
- **Mainly inscribed with proper names in the nominative**
- **Inscriptions in the Euboean dialect**, specifically a Southern Euboean variety



1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)



1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)



1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)

New edition of the tablets from Styra

<https://www.esag.swiss/eretria-series/eretria-xxvii/>

<https://zenodo.org/records/17257282>

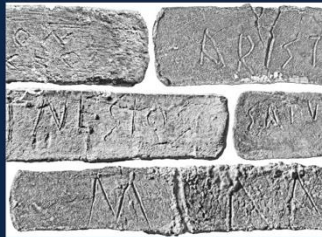
ERETRIA XXVII

Fouilles et recherches

Francesca Dell'Oro

LES LAMELLES DE STYRA

Nouvelle édition avec
étude paléographique, dialectologique et onomastique



1. The tablets from Styra (Euboea)

- example of reuse

ANTIMAXO ΔΙΚΙΟΣ [ANTIMACHO DIKIOS]



2. Between epigraphical and philological edition

- **Epigraphical editorial approach:** extant and complete tablets
- **Philological editorial approach:** lost tablets known through earlier editions
- **Combined epigraphical-philological editorial approach:** fragmentary tablets



2. Between epigraphical and philological edition

- **Epigraphical editorial approach:** extant and complete tablets

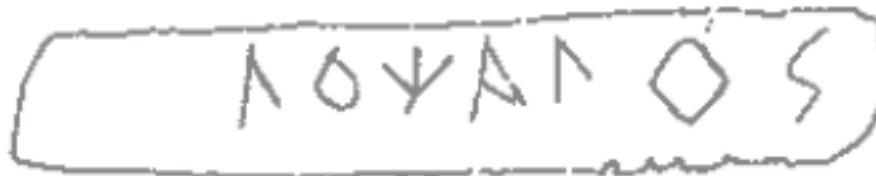
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    <div type="edition" xml:space="preserve">
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        <lb n="1"/> <name nymRef="Master_names.xml#Aισχυλίων" ref="https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Aischylios">Aισχυλίο<sup>#772</sup>;v</name>
      </ab>
    </div>
  </body>
</text>
```



2. Between epigraphical and philological edition

- **Philological editorial approach:** lost tablets known through earlier editions

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    <div type="edition" xml:space="preserve">
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        <lb n="1"/>
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              ref="https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Aglōcharēs">Άγλωχάρης</name>
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        </app>
      </ab>
    </div>
  </body>
</text>
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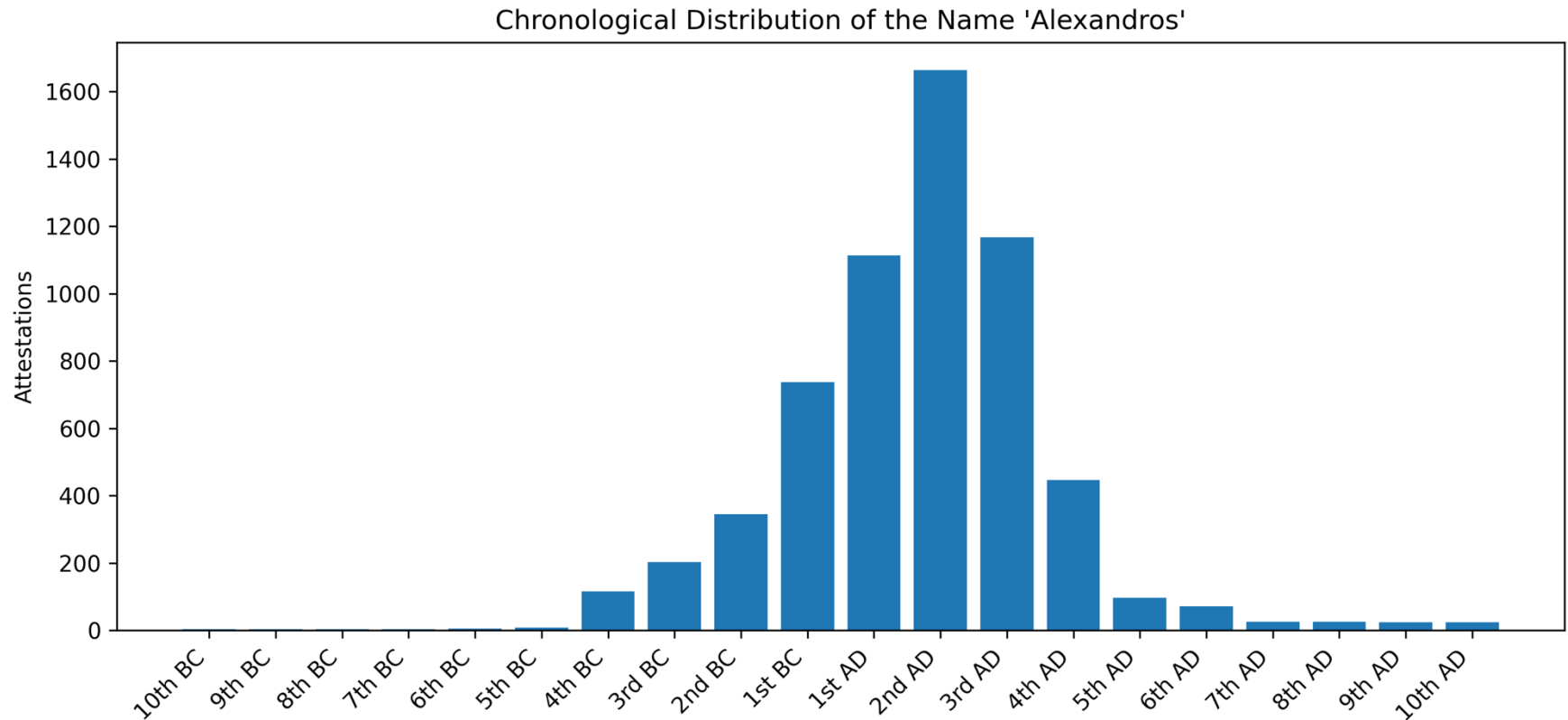


3. The linguistics of proper names

- Semantic transparency was a pervasive feature of personal names in Ancient Greece
 - *Demokritos* 'chosen by the people'
 - *Perikles* 'very glorious'
 - *Sokrates* 'of safe strength'
- This is no longer the case in modern English or Italian (but see *Joy* or *Gioia*)
- Psychological and socio-cultural factors
 - *Alexandros* 'defending the men' → after the conquests of Alexander the Great (356–323 BCE), the name became closely associated with this historical figure



3. The linguistics of proper names



Data taken from the LGPN database



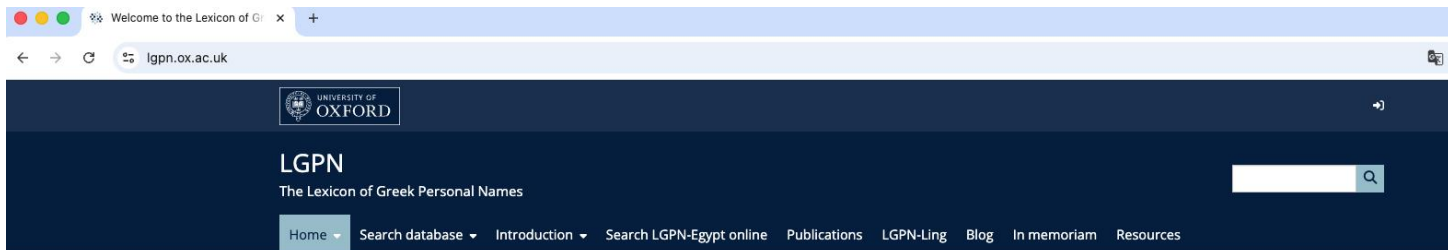
3. The linguistics of proper names

LGPN: historical/geographical distribution

LGPN-Ling: linguistic analysis (morphology and semantics)

If you want to know more about the geographical and historical distribution of Ancient Greek personal names:

<https://www.lgpn.ox.ac.uk/>



Welcome to the Lexicon of Greek Personal Names



Ancient Greek names are an important resource for the historian of the ancient Mediterranean world. They may reveal where people came from; they show what gods were popular at a given time; they can express political ideals; they illuminate cultural contact in the many regions outside Greece where Greek became the dominant language.

The **Lexicon of Greek Personal Names (LGPN)** traces every bearer of every name, drawing on a huge variety of evidence, from personal tombstones, dedications, works of art, to civic decrees, treaties, citizen-lists, artefacts, graffiti etc.: in other words, from all Greek literary sources, documentary sources (inscriptions and papyri), coins, and artefacts. Because it records not just every name but every bearer of each name, it can be seen as the closest



3. The linguistics of proper names

LGPN: historical/geographical distribution

LGPN-Ling: linguistic analysis (morphology and semantics)

If you want to discover the meanings of Ancient Greek personal names:

<https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/about.html>

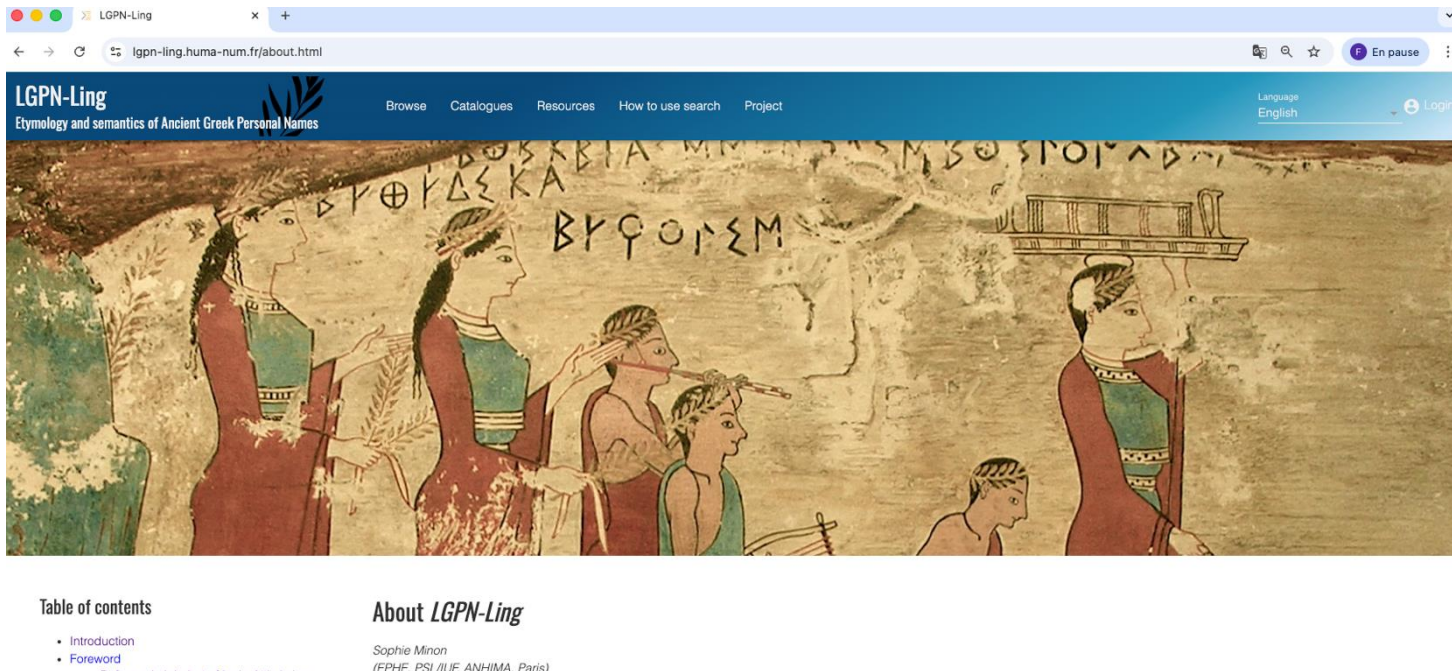


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- Introduction
- Foreword

About *LGPN-Ling*

Sophie Minon
(EPHE, PSL/UF, ANHIMA, Paris)



3. The linguistics of proper names

I< 1 >I Found 1 item

Sort by Name Filter by Name Filter Q aglochares

Name	Geolinguistic	Prefix	Bases Root1	Root2	PN Suffixes S.4 S.3 S.2 S.1	Bases Morphosyntax (PN Genetics)	Semantics
Ἀγλωχάρης Aglōcharēs -ης Early -εος, Att. -ους, A.M. -ευσ, then -ε(ι)ου(ς)	Euboean, Cycladic Ionic		αγλα(φ)(ο)	χαρ-(εσ)		Adj—V YX	sparkling, brilliant- rejoiced
LGPN Q 2[m.] -500/-400 Trismegistos							
Ἀγλώχαρος	Cycladic Ionic	m					



3. The linguistics of proper names

- to avoid repetition, in the digital edition of the tablets, reference is made to the LGPN-Ling database:

```
<name nymRef="Master_names.xml#Αγλωχάρης"  
      ref="https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Aglochares">Αγλοχάρης&#772;ς</name>
```



3. The linguistics of proper names

- Editions may enrich the text with additional linguistic and onomastic metadata
- For example: dialectal variants, frequency of attestation (hapax), external identifiers
- Such information can be managed through an authority file



3. The linguistics of proper names

```
<nym xml:id="Τιμίνης">
  <form type="lemma">
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    <usg type="dialect">Euboean</usg>
    <measure type="attestations">1</measure>
  </form>
  <form type="variant">
    <orth>Τιμίνας</orth>
    <usg type="dialect">North-West Doric</usg>
    <usg type="dialect">Boeotian</usg>
    <ref type="LGPN-Ling">https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Timinas</ref>
  </form>
  <note type="editorial">
    LGPN records the name as
    <ref target="http://clas-lgpn2.classics.ox.ac.uk/Τιμνίνης/">Τιμνίνης</ref>,
    following an earlier reading rejected in the present edition.
  </note>
</nym>
```



4. Conclusions

This presentation has shown

- how epigraphic and philological approaches were combined both in editing the tablets from Styra and in encoding their edition using XML-TEI
- how the linguistic features of Ancient Greek personal names can be identified, analysed and encoded using XML-TEI



EXERCISE 1

1. Using the TEI Guidelines and the example discussed above, suggest an encoding for the apparatus the following tablet from Styra. The tablet is no longer extant, and earlier editors have proposed different readings.

STY 263 = LOU 48

Identification : Lambros 42 = MNB 3188.63. Conservation : lamelle introuvable.

Éditions : liste Vischer – Lambros n° 113 (liste Lambros n° 42), Lenormant (1867 : n° 53), Roehl (1882 : n° 112), Bechtel (1887 : n° 197), Audollent (1904 : n° 120), Ziebarth (1915 : n° 126). Dessins : Lenormant (1867 : n° 53) [Roehl (1882 : n° 112)].

Εὐτέλῃς

Apparat : ΕΥΤΕΛΕΣ Vischer, Εὐτέλης Bechtel : Εὐτελές Audollent, Εὐγένης Lenormant.



```
...
<div>
  <div type="edition" xml:space="preserve">
    <ab>
      <lb n="1"/>
      <app>
        <lem> ... </lem>
        <rdg resp= "...">. ... </rdg>
      </app>
    </ab>
  </div>
```

Solution exercise 1

```
<div type="edition" xml:space="preserve">
  <ab>
    <lb n="1"/>
    <app>
      <lem>
        <name nymRef="Master_names.xml#Εὐτέλης"
          ref="https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Eutelēs">Εὐτέλες</name>
      </lem>
      <rdg resp="#Vischer">ΕΥΤΕΛΕΣ</rdg>
      <rdg resp="#Bechtel">Εὐτέλης</rdg>
      <rdg resp="#Audollent">Εὐτελέες</rdg>
      <rdg resp="#Lenormant">Εὐγένης</rdg>
    </app>
  </ab>
</div>
```



EXERCISE 2

2) encode the diatopic variants of the name Κλεογενίδης/Κλογενίδης (STY 180) in the authority file

Name	Geolinguistic	Bases		PN Suffixes			Bases Morphosyntax (PN Genetics)	Semantics
		Prefix	Root1	Root2	S.4	S.3		
Κλευγενίδας	South Doric		κλε(Ϝ)-(ε)(σ)	γεν-(εσ)	(ι)δ	ᾱ/ης	N—N	fame, glory-kin, birth,
Kleugenidas							YX	origin, born
-ᾱ/ης								
Att. -ου, Ion., A.M. -εω etc., Beot. -ᾶο, Dor. -ᾶ								
LGPN 								
1[m.]								
-600/-500								
Trismegistos								
Κλεογενίδης	Euboean	m						
Κλογενίδης	Euboean	m						



<nym xml:id="Κλεογενίδης">

<form type="lemma">

<orth> ... </orth>

<usg type="dialect"> ... </usg>

</form>

<ref type="LGPN-Ling"> ... </ref>

</nym>

Solution exercise 2

```
<nym xml:id="Κλεογενίδης">  
  <form type="lemma">  
    <orth>Κλεογενίδης</orth>  
    <usg type="dialect">Euboean</usg>  
  </form>  
  
  <form type="variant">  
    <orth>Κλογενίδης</orth>  
    <usg type="dialect">Euboean</usg>  
  </form>  
  
  <form type="variant">  
    <orth>Κλεογενίδας</orth>  
    <usg type="dialect">South Doric</usg>  
  </form>  
  
  <ref type="LGPN-Ling">https://lgpn-ling.huma-num.fr/Kleugenidas</ref>  
</nym>
```





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Thank you!
Merci!
Grazie!

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